

SPORTS ▼

BLADES OF GLORY

With a bronze at the recent Asia Cup, **WOMEN'S ICE HOCKEY** in India seems to be coming of age

Around the start of the year, the Indian national women's ice hockey team was in a predicament. They were scheduled to compete at the Women's Asia Cup in the UAE (May 31-June 6); it's just that they didn't have a facility where they could train. It took several stakeholders to come together to renovate the ice rink at Maharana Pratap Sports College, Dehradun. But it wasn't until the first week of May that the team finally had access to it.

The team put the setbacks aside to take on the grind under Canadian coach Darrin Harrold, putting in four hours of work each day. And their efforts paid dividends on June 6 when they picked up bronze at the tournament, the first major podium finish for the senior team. Important wins over Malaysia, the UAE and Kyrgyzstan helped them to their success.

"Given the struggles we've gone through in the past, it's overwhelming to see the appreciation that's come our way. We've had young girls come up and tell us that they are inspired to do even better than us," says Diskit Angmo, who struck a crucial equaliser against Kyrgyzstan to take the game to overtime, followed by a shootout that India eventually won.

So far, the sport has flourished in pockets of Ladakh and Himachal Pradesh, mostly during winters, when temporary rinks are set up on frozen water bodies. Female players in the past have struggled with everything—from appropriate gear and equipment to playing opportunities. But the facility in Dehradun can be a game-changer for the sport.

"This year, we want to conduct a test run for a domestic league for men, women and under-18s. It will not only give players the opportunity to hone their skills, but also allow us to fulfil the minimum playing standards as required by the international federation. The idea is to compete at the World Division level in the future," says Harjinder Singh Jindi, general secretary of Ice Hockey Association of India. ■

—Shail Desai

CRICKET ▼

Powering Ahead

AFTER HER SECOND ODI CENTURY LAST MONTH, **JEMIMAH RODRIGUES** IS LOOKING FORWARD TO HER ENGLAND TOUR IN END-JUNE

Q. What were your thoughts when you walked in to bat at 50/3 in the must-win tie against South Africa in May?

My mindset was simple: to build a solid partnership with Smriti [Mandhana]. The plan was to keep things straightforward, take singles off every ball and in case of a loose delivery, put it away for a boundary or six. I focused on playing risk-free, sensible cricket.

Q. Two hundreds in 2025, including the first of your ODI career. How important was it to finally get that hundred?

Scoring a hundred is always special, but to finally get my first in ODIs, and to do it in a must-win game makes it even more meaningful. 2025 has been a year where I've tried to simplify my game, stay present and trust the work I've put in behind the scenes.

Q. What are the things you've been working on ahead of the England series in June?

The focus has been on fine-

Jemimah has been working on **playing late and adapting to the extra bounce and movement** that English pitches usually offer

